suffered such a grievous loss, but they had not forgotten to look after their guest. There was kahwa, dry fruits and an assortment of biscuits. Kashmiris are known for their hospitality and this was ample proof of it. That first visit was awkward, but it helped show that we cared.

I visited them many times after that to see how they were getting along. On Jameel's first death anniversary, I made it a point to drop in on them. By now, the people had got used to my visits. The village children would crowd around my vehicles waiting for the toffees I customarily distributed at the end of each visit. On the occasion of Eid, I gave them some ready money so that they could buy themselves new clothes and celebrate in a befitting manner. Before long, they had all become part of my extended circle of friends. Clasping my hand in hers, Jameel's mother would reminisce.

'Jameel was such a good boy. He was not like the others who go around extorting money. Now who will look after us?'

'*Mauji*, don't worry. We are here to look after you. Jameel was one of us, like one of my jawans. We'll look after you.'

'But you'll go one day. Then who will care for us? Only you recognize how much Jameel was worth.'

This was true in a way and very perceptive of the old lady. I would finish my tour of duty one day and push off to greener pastures. They would be the ones left behind, fighting their lonely battle. During the past ten years, they must have seen many officers like me come and go. Some must have been well-intentioned, others perhaps not. Theirs was an uncertain future but life had to go on. They would only be left with memories of times not long past when Kashmir was indeed paradise on earth.

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